

HONEST FOOD by **James McIntosh™**

FOOD YOU CAN HAVE FAITH IN



James McIntosh
Limited

Belfast Focus on Food Conference

St George's Market, Belfast, Northern Ireland

17th February 2015

Honest Food™

by James McIntosh

**Belfast Focus on Food Conference,
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FINAL

STRICT EMBARGO UNTIL 11am 17th February 2015

SLIDE 1: INTRO SLIDE

***[James to walk onto stage. Stand still for a few
seconds, survey the crowd]***

Thank you, for being here today.

Thank you for supporting Northern Ireland and thank you to
Belfast City Council, Tourism Northern Ireland, Department
of Agriculture and Rural Development, Food NI and Morrow
Communications for organising today.

[Pause]

SLIDE 2: 'BOUT YE?

Minister. Deputy Lord Mayor. Sponsors. Ladies and Gentleman.

[Pause, big smile to audience, relax]

It's a delight to be with you today... my name is James McIntosh... and it's great to be home.

I'm here to talk about food, to talk about Northern Ireland as a centre of food excellence and about getting the message of this little gem that is Northern Ireland out to the wider world.

SLIDE 3: BALLYLISK

When I left my family home of Ballylisk House between Tandragee and Portadown I was excited like any teenager moving away. I didn't know back then – almost twenty years ago... that I was about to embark on a voyage around the world in search of food excellence... only to find the best in the world was where I call home.

My mother was a home economics teacher and her advice to me was very simple – “*do it once son, and do it right*” – which seems to be excellent advice for those contemplating a career in food or for those considering marriage!

SLIDE 4: DAD AND I ON TRACTOR

My father bred Aberdeen Angus cattle and gave me my first experience in ploughing in the Mullahead and District Ploughing Championship which convinced me of two things

– I wasn't a bad ploughman, in fact I won a prize... and secondly and much more important I wasn't going to pursue a career in primary production.

My mum and dad taught me a great deal... but perhaps more important than anything was that the journey is one from plough to plate... what goes in the ground shows on the plate... the purity of home produced food... as relevant today as it has always been.

The Catering College in Portrush was my first introduction to formal food education and the Higher National Diploma I studied there taught me more about business life and food delivery than anything that came after it. It doesn't surprise me in the least that some of the most successful restaurants in Northern Ireland are situated along the North Coast... the message of course is that if we invest in skills and develop our competencies, economic value will follow.

I should also mention Portadown College here, if for no other reason than Geoff Telford who sat beside me in Chemistry is now a world-class food photographer. I'm delighted to say that most of the images you see here are Geoff's and I think he has done a tremendous job – thank you Geoff.

For the record, I now live in Peckham, not far from '*Nelson Mandela Towers*': the famous abode of Dell Boy from '*Only Fools and Horses*'... with my partner, and our two cats; Gloria and Gaynor not forgetting Angus, my new, beloved, AGA City60 cooker.

Can I just mention that the Northern Ireland accent is now considered the sexiest in the English-speaking world? You only have to turn on the TV and it's Jimmy Nesbitt or Jamie Dornan or Liam Neeson or that big lad in "*Silent Witness*".

You can't escape the accent wherever you are in the world... I used to be a bit self-conscious of it but now I use it as a selling point! I used to occasionally lapse into a Mid-shires accent in my TV work but I '*wised up*' and said "*hold on here, this is something I'm proud of*"... this actually sounds better than the rest!

SLIDE 5: ANDREW COWAN

So enter Andrew Cowan, CEO of Northern Irish Connections into my life. He's a likeable guy,... finds out who you are... where you're from... and what you're up to. He gets to know you and before you know it... he's asked you to bring a conference home to Belfast. He describes it as "*only a hundred people, like, so I'll leave it with ye... sure you'll get back to me*". So I did.

I said to him... *“ Andrew,... what about 3,000 people for the world cookbook awards in Belfast, sure why don’t you get back to me – chew on it”*.

But Andrew did get back to me and that’s why I’m standing here today. I told him about a vision I had and he bought into it.

My time in London has been filled with mostly success and the occasional failure. I admit to being a workaholic. I’m resilient... You have to be in this business. I’ll concentrate on some of my successes if you don’t mind... I’ve been rather fortunate, all thanks to my early experiences at home and some very hard work since I left.

SLIDE 6: AGA

I’m a global ambassador for AGA and Rangemaster cookers...

SLIDE 7: FARMERS WEEKLY AWARDS

In 2012, Lord Coe awarded me the first prize as Farmer's Weekly Magazine's, Britain's food ambassador of the year for my work in China... I'm the kitchen manager at the coveted Quality Food Awards running a team of 20 and a never-ending pipeline of 1,300 food products to be cooked for judging.

SLIDE 8: GOURMAND BOOK AWARD

I've written 9 cookery books... I've won the Gourmand World Cookbook Award for best series of cookbooks in the world... and I present food TV in China. I go there a lot.

China has been very good to me, yet it's tough out there, I've been visiting China since 2009 and I've taken the rough with the smooth... what I now find, however, is that I can do

more business in one week in China than I can in one year in London.

SLIDE 9: GOURMAND TV AWARD

I was awarded Best Food TV presenter in the world for my work out there...

SLIDE 10: CHINA MEDIA AWARD

and in 2011 my series '*Food Adventures on the Silk Road 2*' won the Chinese TV and Radio Award - it was the first time a Westerner won such a media award in China...

SLIDE 11: WISS

in my spare time, I'm a patron for the Western International School of Shanghai.

SLIDE 12: DONKEY TAIL

I have 3 rules for eating food in China:

- 1 Is it beige? Then it could be safe to eat, move to step 2.
- 2 Does it move when I touch it with my chopstick?

Then...

- 3 Eat, swallow, and smile for the camera!

SLIDE 13: IRWIN'S BAKERY

I still get flashbacks to the summers when at Portadown College when my food career started as a '*Nutty Krust slicer*' for Irwin's Bakery. Had I gone wrong somewhere that I was now eating donkey for breakfast? Chinese porridge, if you can call it that is called Congee,

SLIDE 14: TASTE OF TANDRAGEE

but oh for White's Speedicook Porridge and Tayto Cheese and Onion crisps. Nothing compares to the '*Taste of Tandragee*'.

The truth of the matter is that I get 1 billion viewers on my TV show in China... I write for a food magazine called '*East Eat*' that prints 40 million copies a month... and this is the scale of the vision that I want to introduce you today...

I've just come home from there for the umpteenth time, stroked the cats as usual. Cooked a soufflé – one does weird things with jet-lag and I'm going back again in 3 weeks to launch AGA cookers in China. This time, with Speedicook in toe. Believe it or not, it's one of the first times an '*oven*' will be used in China for cooking purposes. Wok burners have been the sole way to cook for 3,000 years. I launched my own food brand in Hong Kong called Honest Food™. I really have grown to like the Far East for very obvious reasons.

So, anyway, Andrew and I continued our conversations and basically he convinced me to try to bring back home some

of what I had learnt along the way and, in the process, hopefully make a difference to the food industry and the overall economy in Northern Ireland.

My sense, as I've said, is that food was always better at home, yet equally there was always something new and exciting happening in London and elsewhere with food.

What I missed however with all of my running around was that something exciting was happening at home as well... on my visits home to see family and present AGA cookery demos on the Castlereagh Road and when writing for Northern Ireland's Flavour magazine, I discovered we were getting our "*food confidence*". A new confidence.

So I set about applying what I'd learned and the experience I'd gained in the world of marketing and media into a plan for NI food. And do you know what they said... they said "*no*" to my first pitch. But bear this in mind... in 1962 Decca

Records turned down the Beatles in favour of Brian Poole and The Tremelos... that's all anyone needs to know about rejection! And to think Paul McCartney now has his own cookbook!

SLIDE 15: MICHELE SHIRLOW

...So I kept going because by then I'd met a fantastic supporter in the person of Michele Shirlow, CEO of Food NI / Taste of Ulster. She is like me in female form. She is fun, she knows her stuff, she is committed and loyal and will not stop at anything. Michele, thank you for the confidence you've shown in me and help and friendship you have given me these past months. Northern Ireland is very lucky to have you as a food visionary and leader.

SLIDE 16: SHORCROSS GIN

Michele introduced me to some of her members, Shorcross Gin. Northern Ireland's first premium craft gin. From

Crossgar. I've been to the distillery, and the truth is David and Fiona Boyd-Armstrong can't make enough of the stuff. 10 months old, and what a phenomenal success story for Northern Ireland.

SLIDE 17: MASH DIRECT

I first came across Mash Direct when it was entered into the Quality Food Awards and I had a phone call from Comber saying my spuds were being delivered in *their van* to Hammersmith for 6am the next morning. Now, you *can't* get a good spud in England. They are too soapy and waxy. A van in London that delivers Comber spuds to your door I had to discover. And now they do. To Peckham, the posh part, and they are employing about 150 people as a Northern Irish company.

SLIDE 18: LEGGYGOWAN FARM

Adam Kelly, and his goats milk products from Leggygowan farm. His goat's cheese is competing in quality with the very best available Goats Cheese from France.

SLIDE 19: BROIGHTER GOLD

Leona Kane at Broighter Gold for her beautifully mellow Cold Pressed Rapeseed Oil that has more health benefits than olive oil and comes to a higher temperature when cooking.

SLIDE 20: ABERNEATHY BUTTER

I then met Will and Allison Aberneathy and was bowled over by their homemade butter. I need to get the bus from Peckham to Piccadilly for Fortnum and Mason to get his products, but happily worth the trip.

And I met many, many more excellent producers, not to mention a newly exploded restaurant scene.

SLIDE 21: GOAT

What was clear, is that we have a new confidence in Northern Ireland. What we lost in the past, we have rediscovered in our food. I was now ready to produce my plan. It's called '*Beyond the Plate*'. I saw the future of Northern Ireland sitting on my plate. And it was all about Honest Food™.

When you sit down for dinner what you see before you is a plate of food. Let's consider a way to look beyond the plate, beyond the recipe. It's an approach which aims to stimulate the economy, to reclaim tradition and health, to empower farmers, food producers and chefs. It's the power of cuisine.

'You are what you eat' is a common phrase used to describe over nutrition in the developed world. When it comes to dining it is also true that *'you are who you eat with'*.

SLIDE 22: DINNER TABLE

Some of the best times we have are when we are with others. We share and we learn. Many times, this is around the dinner table. At the table we are all the same. It's not a place for prejudice between black and white, gay and straight, Muslim or Christian or Protestant or Catholic. It's a time to talk about the day that has passed, to commune in fellowship with each other. We learn from each other.

I have been lucky that my career, including working for some of the biggest and most respected brands in food and kitchen appliances means I am seen as a world leader in food media, especially in the Far East. Food is in my blood, yet the development in the late 1980's of the *'celebrity chef'*

never really appealed to me. The notion of '*how to cook the perfect...*' is not a reality for the home. Something was missing. One could successfully argue that food is the one thing, even more so than sport, that brings us together. Surely we are all the same at the table? You see the food communities from plough to plate intertwine. Like the Northern Irish accent the reality of food production is with us from birth.

So, my vision. Well, it is a 3-step process:

1. Food and Tourism
2. Our Food Status globally
3. Global media development

SLIDE 23: STAGE 1

Stage 1 - Food and Tourism

Sadly, not everyone has a chance to eat enough in this world. One questions how the food world is dominated by the concept of '*profit*' and '*non-profit*'. It is very different from the value system I grew up with where food was for everyone as it was grown at home. Trends of buying local are currently at the fore.

SLIDE 24: BALLYWALTER PARK

This can be very well illustrated with OX restaurant in Belfast buying meat from Ballywalter Estate.

SLIDE 25: HASTINGS HOTELS GROUP

and the Hastings Hotels Group having information cards on the breakfast table about the provenance of their food. In both these examples the menu is clearly the creative glue that joins tourism and agriculture. The power of a restaurant comes to life here, where the chef can be a significant investor in the local economy. These menus are simply the

business plan of Northern Ireland. It is so heartening to see that local chefs believe Northern Irish food is good enough for their menus in an age of global availability. The Hastings Hotels Group are great leaders in this with the '*Who made my breakfast?*' booklet on the table. When local food is in tourism it becomes tourism for everybody. Farmers, fishermen to artisanal makers and so on. One only has to look at the fantastic food in Thailand, the colours and smells and flavour in the markets run by families who cook local foods and feature regularly in Rick Stein's most favoured flavours. Stage one has been activated here... **getting local cuisine into tourism.**

SLIDE 26: STAGE 2

Stage 2 - Food Status Globally

Thai, French, Chinese and Italian cuisines are recognised globally. Can Northern Ireland claim the same?... well we have some excellent products as I've mentioned but "*brand*

Northern Ireland” for cuisine is not on the global radar. Part of this of course is our problem. We look at food overseas as superior. We are clearly good at hosting conferences and many other things besides... but is food a core ingredient for tourism here?... Not to our full potential is the answer. Food is a cultural sense of self and a deeply personal one at that. We all remember what our mother’s made for us... how they re-cycled left over lunch to dinner. Here we share food with stories of the day... we create relationships as we share food... we build communities around food. In many ways I believe that the story of our food is an important insight into the story of our people. My belief is that the time for Northern Ireland food has arrived and it is time to get that story out into the wider world. If we can embed our Northern Ireland food identity into a much wider audience abroad then we will have made a real difference from the plough to the plate. And the reason I’m here today is to share the “how” with you.

SLIDE 27: STAGE 3

Stage 3 - Global Media Development

SLIDE 28: COOKBOOKS

Writing a cookbook in an intelligent way highlights the country, the community and the cuisine. Society has wakened up to relationship between diet and health and having the right food culture is one key aspect of this.

Healthy individuals within a healthy, happy and prosperous community. And you know... books form the basis of authority on which to plan other actions.

SLIDE 29: LEADERS WRITE COOKBOOKS

Leaders write cookbooks, Michele Obama, Helmut Kohl, Paul McCartney, Gwyneth Paltrow and so on. The media is a globally powerful development tool. Cookbooks are too.

SLIDE 30: GOURMAND IN BELFAST

To this end I propose we host a global food event such as **Gourmand International in Belfast in 2016 – Our designated Year of Food.**

SLIDE 31: NI MAP

It is difficult to adequately describe the social media impact to be gained when the biggest names in food and drink writing and television food programming from over 200 countries arrive in Northern Ireland... that's more than enter the Olympics or are members of the United Nations. 3,000 food writers... all coming to Belfast to sample the quality ingredients which our farmers and fishermen provide and which our chefs use to create the most amazing dishes. The food tours, province wide. A celebration for the whole Province. And this is exactly what I'm proposing.

To recap, we want to make our produce famous at home, become proud of it and actively promote it. If you don't see it on a menu, ask for it. Make Northern Ireland a food brand that is globally recognised and admired, so we can bring the world of food writers and TV chef's to Northern Ireland to show what we know best from generational learning. Food, with our legendary hospitality.

Simply put, if we can share the story of our food with these writers in a convincing, authentic way, it will appear in every meaningful cookbook in the world, not to mention on food television globally as well. Let's exploit the power of the media. Collectively planned and executed in a positive light for NI.

This is the story of our people through **Northern Irish Connections** and **Food NI**. And it all starts with a simple traybake.

SLIDE 32: 15's

The humble 15... we've all had one. Now every member of the P.W.A., Women's Institute and so on will know that a 15 is all about the same amount of each ingredient:

15 large marshmallows, halved

15 digestive biscuits, crushed

15 glacé cherries, halved

150ml condensed milk

Desiccated coconut

Mix all together except the coconut. Roll into a sausage shape, roll in coconut and wrap in cling film. Put into the fridge. Leave for a couple of hours. Cut into 15 slices - simple.

SLIDE 33: AGA WITH DALEN PRINCIPLES

When the AGA cooker was developed in 1922 by Dr Gustaf Dalén, a blind Nobel Prize winning scientist, he solved the issue of cooking using physics.

He concluded that cooking needed 3 things:

1. The correct ingredients
2. The correct proportion of ingredients
3. The correct application of heat

And hence the AGA was born. Undoubtedly the best cooker in the world.

Well, just like the 15's we have in Northern Ireland we also have the required ingredients for my vision... We have the producers ... We have some of the most beautiful landscape on the planet. What we now have to do is mix

this together in the correct proportions to create excellence – getting it right first time... and that's what we are planning to do. Networking, helping, researching and encouraging.

Finally as Dalén stated, it's the heat, or lack of it as in the 15's that counts to set the mixture. And that's where the media becomes important. Just like cooking, different temperatures are required for different processes. The media is used in different ways for different things.

The French have a term in cooking called '*mise-en-place*', it means to read the recipe first, have in place all of your equipment and ingredients, produce a plan of action and only then, start to cook.

What good is it, after all of the work has been done on obtaining PGI status for 3 of our products,

SLIDE 34: COMBER EARLY POTATOES

Comber Early Potatoes,

SLIDE 35: LOUGH NEAGH EELS

Lough Neagh Eels

SLIDE 36: ARMAGH BRAMLEY APPLES

and Armagh Bramley Apples if they are to be put into a brown box and sold simply as potatoes, eels or apples to a homogenous hotel chain or processor?

I want to tell the world about our Comber Early Potatoes, our Lough Neagh Eels and our Armagh Bramley Apples, well those Bramley's do grown in the fields around Ballylisk House. Sell them as such and we create brand *Northern Ireland*. One only has to think of Parma Ham, Cheddar Cheese and so on. We create an opportunity to be known.

Let's set aside what Wikipedia currently says about Northern Ireland and create a fresh identity for our Province through our food.

SLIDE 37: ROCKY ROAD

But *Rocky Road* I hear you say is more attractive than a 15 and costs more as it's got chocolate in it. Marketing. Plain and simple. And you know what, it's only Northern Ireland that has traybakes. In the Republic of Ireland they have cream buns, so take what you know, be proud of it and sell it to the world. Stick to knitting but do it better than anybody else.

Yes believe it or not, we won the Gourmand pitch against Japan and Australia to host the 20th Gourmand World Cookbook, Drinks Book and Food TV Awards in Northern Ireland. We blew the organiser's away with our hospitality and quality of food. Thank you so much to all of you who

helped to secure this for home, especially to Invest Northern Ireland, Belfast City Council, Northern Ireland Tourist Board, Visit Belfast and the Department of Enterprise, Trade and Investment. This could not have been done without the encouragement, commitment and support of Food NI and Northern Irish Connections. It's been a long, hard road, so thank you for standing by me in this.

SLIDE 38: QUALITY FOOD AWARDS

We know our food has superior quality, but it's when others notable in the food world echo what we know is what really matters, they make authoritative noise on our behalf. As I mentioned earlier, I run the kitchens for the Quality Food Awards. Now in their 36th year. The press coverage and authority of these awards help companies like no other awards. I know all too well the stringent testing from expert judges and the quality controls that are put into place for judging. What is very important is not just the recognition

for the food at these prestigious awards, but the fact that not just the food is considered, and that is a big part, but all of the food including the packaging and the consumer perception to the taste as well as the cooking guidelines. Authority like this helps sales, and brand perception and Northern Ireland is winning more awards, per head of population than any other part of the UK.

SLIDE 39: JAMES IN CHINA

So briefly back to China. I've eaten Tayto Cheese and Onion on the Great Wall. I had a slice of Veda with the Terracotta Warriors and I've made soda bread in the Gobi desert. I've told millions of Chinese about Northern Irish food. So, I decided to bring it to them.

SLIDE 40: HONEST FOOD™

I call it Honest Food™ - food that you can have faith in. Well, it's the hallmarks of my formative years. What is on

the packet is what is in the product, nothing else added, nothing hidden. Others were bringing high calorie foods to a nation that was eating very healthily. Food additives were being hidden in the labelings... But China wanted to have fresher food that was better for health. To that end, they came up with what they called '*Naked Food*'. In response I developed the concept of Honest Food™. I want to bring Northern Irish food to China... Honest food™

SLIDE 41: MUM AND I

...think about the potential that represents. After all it's what my mother fed me, and your mother probably fed you with it too. Through love, to give you and me the best they could.

SLIDE 42: JAMES COLLECTING GOURMAND TV

AWARD IN CHINA

Forgive me, I nearly forgot.

The news is out and it's great for Northern Ireland. In the 2014 Gourmand World Cookbook, Drinks Book and Food TV Awards, often described as the '*Pulitzer of cookbook publishing*'. 5 of our food writers in Northern Ireland have been shortlisted for a total of 9 **Best in the World Awards**. It's the first time Northern Ireland has ever been listed as a country in the awards.

Would you like to hear who?

SLIDE 43: NOEL McMEEL

Best Chef book in the World - Noel McMeel, Irish Pantry, published by Running Press, USA.

SLIDE 44: VIOLA DONO

Best Food Writing in the World- Dreams and Recipes 1904 - 1914 by Viola Dono, published by CreateSpace.

SLIDE 45: EMMETT McCOURT

Best Local Book and Best Culinary Travel Book in the World - Emmett McCourt, Feast or Famine a culinary journey of the North West of Ireland published by Guildhall Press, a Northern Irish publisher.

SLIDE 46: CANCER FOCUS NI

Best Charity Book and Best Health Book in the World - Jeanne Rankin, Deidre Conlon and Niamh McDaid, Well Being cookbook for Cancer Focus Northern Ireland.

SLIDE 47: FOOD NI / TASTE OF ULSTER

Best Digital Food Website, Best Digital Food Institution and Best Culinary Travel in the World, NI Good Food / Taste of Ulster.

Congratulations to you all and best wishes for the Gourmand World Cookbook Awards in Yantai, China in

June. If you have as much as 10% of the opportunities I have been fortunate enough to receive through the Gourmand Best in the World Awards then your life will change. Enjoy it, You are shortlisted to be Best in the World. Currently, the Best in Northern Ireland. I'm proud of you.

Can I also and finally make a brief but important reference to the Agri-food Strategy Board's ambition to grow jobs across the sector by 15,000 and increase Northern Ireland exports by 75%?

I also take my hat off to the Executive's commitment to back this objective with funding to help make it happen... success will depend on having the right people, in the right place with the right skills and competencies at every level of the sector... primary producers, processors, marketeers, finance people, sales teams... each and everyone of them

with a business outlook... anchored to delivering a differentiated product to the changing markets and developing tastes across the world. To do this successfully, of course, we have to get our message out there at every opportunity and using every means at our disposal...

So where does that leave us? Well, I'm here and Andrew and I are still speaking. I'm going to do this for Northern Ireland, if you want me to. Obviously, I need your support and that will involve raising a monetary contribution to match the other money I'm finding. This is not a conventional way of export, it's about winning hearts and minds and there's a bit of saying let's just do it... it's long overdue. Are you with me?

SLIDE 48: POSTCARD

Please take the postcard home that is on your seat. Go to my website and you can download the strategy that I

presented to the NI Government free of charge I might add as this presentation is too. Sign up to be part of my global Honest Food™ Revolution for Northern Ireland. As I said earlier, I have flown around the world with food to find the best is actually where I started.

I have a dream and a vision for home; I've done things like this in other countries. Please, help me to make home famous for the right reasons and to change what Wikipedia has to say about Northern Ireland. Let's be famous for our food and get inward tourism anchored to the best that we can offer. They say perfection is something we seek in everyone but ourselves – so let's change that... Let's make Northern Ireland the perfect home for food.

May God Bless you, and our Province.